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The newspaper began in January 1888 as the London Financial Guide but changed its name a month later to the Financial Times (FT). For many years, it competed with the Financial News (FN), and both focused mainly on financial news.

In 1919, the FT was bought by the Berry family, who also owned the Sunday Times. In 1945, they sold it to the FN, and the two papers merged under the Financial Times name. Most senior staff came from the FN. After this, the FT became the world's largest financial newspaper, famous for its light-pink paper. Over time, it expanded to cover opinion columns, special reports, political cartoons, book reviews, technology, and global politics, while staying focused on free trade and free markets.

The FT also grew internationally, adding foreign correspondents and printing in Frankfurt (1979) and the USA (1985). Its website, ft.com, launched in 1996. In 2015, the Nikkei group bought the Financial Times Group from Pearson for \$844 million.